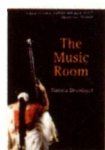


THE LOST MELODIES

A resonant memoir takes us into the hidden core of the cloistered world of Hindustani music



THE MUSIC ROOM
by NAMITA DEVIDAYAL
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■ By Sunil Sethi

Take two simple words of everyday usage in spoken Hindustani: *dhyan* and *khayal*. They both mean thought. But in the world of Hindustani classical music, they denote complex compositions that are arcane, rigorous and deeply reflective. The egalitarian and free-spirited world of Indian music can open at all levels—and is open to all. At recent free concerts in Delhi's public parks by some of the country's finest musicians that an enlightened municipality has started bestowing upon its citizens, I noticed that tired bicycle commuters flung down their vehicles to join connoisseurs, college students and tourists for a few moments of soul upliftment.

There would be no film music without the *sargam* or an understanding of raga structures; there would be no bhajan or spiritual invocation either. Like musical traditions elsewhere, the Indian tradition is at once powerfully sacred and secular. The classical style of dhrupad, for example, is derived from incantations of the Sama Veda, yet its finest exponents, the Dagar family, practitioners for 19 generations, are Muslim. The teaching of music is a journey through mind and collective memory. But it is not for the faint-hearted.

Learning and yearning is not the same thing. A fug of opaque mysticism and mathematical inflections can separate appreciation from musical practice. Unlike Western classical, Indian music is principally an oral tradition—there is no sheet music—and the delivery and delineation of a raga (there are

hundreds of ragas) depend on a series of half and quarter notes, *shrutis*, that will alter the melody and the mood. Like ancient lapidaries, great Indian musicians do not easily part with their jewels. Divas like Kishori Amonkar or Lata Mangeshkar (and I have had the good fortune of taping interviews with both) struggle to explain the inexplicable. Here's what Lata says: "God resides in the notes. Every colour of human emotion is in the *swar*." And Amonkar: "I try to create an architecture of sound by exploring the micro notes between the notes."

Their words sound like divine interventions but do they illuminate the path for the modern listener? No. Although there is a capable body of literature in regional languages that delves into the

from the insular, wealthy preserves of Cumballa Hill to learn music in a sub-let room in a chawl in the raffish quarter of Kennedy Bridge, two miles away as the crow flies. Here lived the saintly, unmarried Dhondutai Kulkarni, a Brahmin born in Kohlapur who had learnt from Burji Khan, the son of the legendary Alladiya Khan of the Jaipur gharana.

Half a century in age separates the reluctant pupil and her coaxing teacher. "You could become my Kesarbai," says Dhondutai, in the hope that her favourite student will manage to emulate the pain and controversy that surrounded the genius of Kesarbai Kerkar—a singer so secretive and seductive that recordings of her voice are rare. Two lives are mirrored here: the *guru-shishya* relation-



SOUND OF MUSIC: Ustad Alladiya Khan and Dhondutai Kulkarni (right)

musical lives of the great performers, there isn't much in English. Writers like Amit Chaudhuri, Mohan Nadkarni, C.S. Lakshmi, Vikram Seth and the late Sheila Dhar have shed light on some aspects. But there has been an aching void waiting to be filled with the story of Indian sound.

Namita Devidayal, a Princeton-educated financial journalist in Mumbai, has now done it. In *The Music Room*, she takes us into the hidden core of that cloistered world. Hers is a straight-from-the-heart memoir, but she uses fictive elements to expand on a true story. As a 10-year-old, she was taken, kicking and screaming, by her mother,



ship that traverses boundaries of dislocation and class, tutelage and bondage, mediocrity and stardom ("Late nights and too many cigarettes," sighs the author) in a quest that is told in chiselled prose.

Diverting from the mainstream melody, Devidayal flutters off into elevated *taans* and glittering *gamaks* to answer, in a spellbinding narrative, all your questions about north Indian classical music. There are several errors, of fact and musical grammar, that will need correction in future editions. Devidayal has audaciously posed for the cover. And what more alluring image could there be than of a young woman at a tanpura? It's a resonant opening to an outstanding debut. ■